The air in Halle or Leipzig was about twice as dirty as in Duesseldorf or Tokyo. The dirt and smog were mainly produced by soft coal which supplied about 6 per cent of GDR energy and put out much more sulphur dioxide, dust and ashes than other raw materials. There were too few dams and reservoirs, meaning industrial enterprises used the same water up to five times. Add to that the fact that 50 per cent of household sewage flowed unpurified into the environment, deteriorating drinking water supplies. East German drinking water in some regions contained up to 260 milligrams of nitrate per litre – a dangerous amount.

Remarkably, the neglect of environmental protection was even criticised in the official organ of the Central Council of the SED youth organisation. ‘For economic and political necessities, it is impossible at the moment to solve comprehensively the discrepancy between the required effectiveness of the national economy and the necessary environmental protection.’ Instead of investing to eliminate the damage to the environment, FORUM lamented, ‘some enterprises prefer to pay high fines regularly, which is considerably cheaper’.7

Meanwhile, during the upheaval in the Soviet Union, political clouds gathered over Gorbachev as the conservative old guard accused him of pushing reform too far, too fast. Since taking office, he had launched his restructuring, known as ‘perestroika’, alongside a crusade against alcoholism, crime, indifference, laziness and mismanagement, and raged about the deficiencies of an economy that, as he put it, could make a spacecraft rendezvous with Venus but ‘cannot supply its own people with enough food, consumer goods and healthcare’.

While Honecker agreed Soviet society was ripe for transformation, he was stunned at the giddying speed of change. Of particular concern were reforms reducing the Party’s ability to meddle in economic decisions, new press freedoms (which allowed journalists to criticise past mistakes and poke scorn at officials who committed new ones), the slashing of billions spent on subsidising food and the introduction of more ‘democracy’. Aggravating his distrust was the appointment of a special party commission to investigate the rights and wrongs of Stalin’s purges and the rehabilitation of his victims.